

Reddit Data Collection: Initial vs. Revised Scrape

Methodology note for the AI-in-Sharing-Economy project

May 28, 2026

1 Why we changed the scrape

Our **initial** collection searched *all of Reddit* with a single keyword query ("AI rental platform helpful automation trust"). Reddit treats this as an any-word relevance match, so it returned whatever threads happened to contain *any* of those words. Inspecting the result showed the corpus was dominated by unrelated viral threads (relationship drama, K-pop, gaming, US politics) — less than 1% of comments actually mentioned *rental*.

The **revised (v2)** collection instead searches *inside* topic-relevant subreddits (sharing economy, peer-to-peer rentals, camera/drone gear, event tech, AI tooling) and caps comments per thread so no single viral thread dominates. This produces a smaller but genuinely on-topic corpus.

2 Size and structure

Table 1: The initial scrape is 29x larger but topically scattered; v2 is small and focused.

	Version	Comments	Threads	Subreddits	
Initial (keyword, all-Reddit)			14090	59	49
Revised v2 (subreddit-targeted)			483	44	11

3 What dominated each corpus

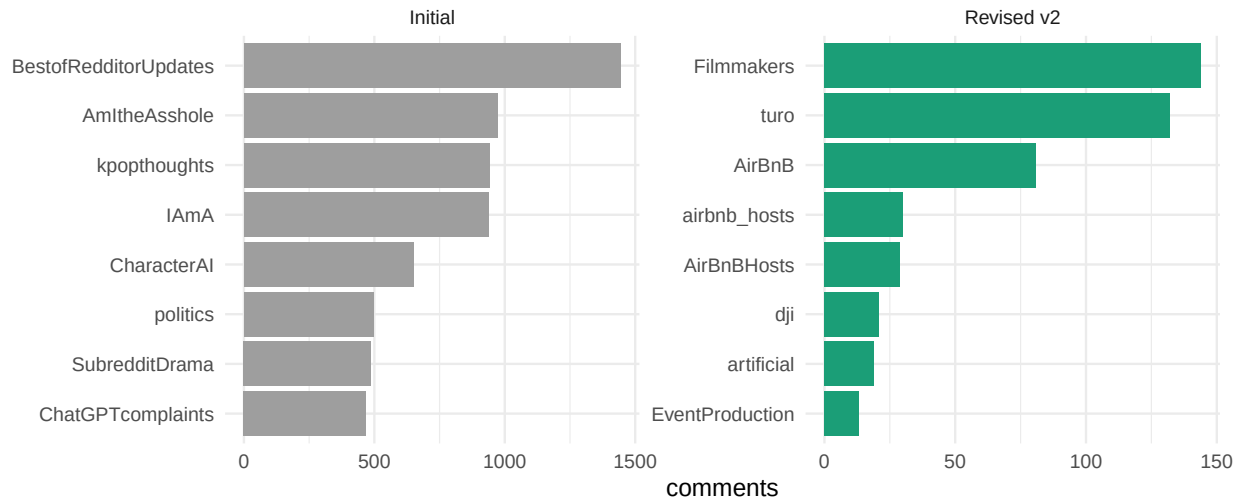


Figure 1: Top subreddits. Initial scrape (grey) is relationship drama, K-pop and gaming; revised scrape (green) is the sharing-economy and AI communities the project actually needs.

4 On-topic keyword coverage

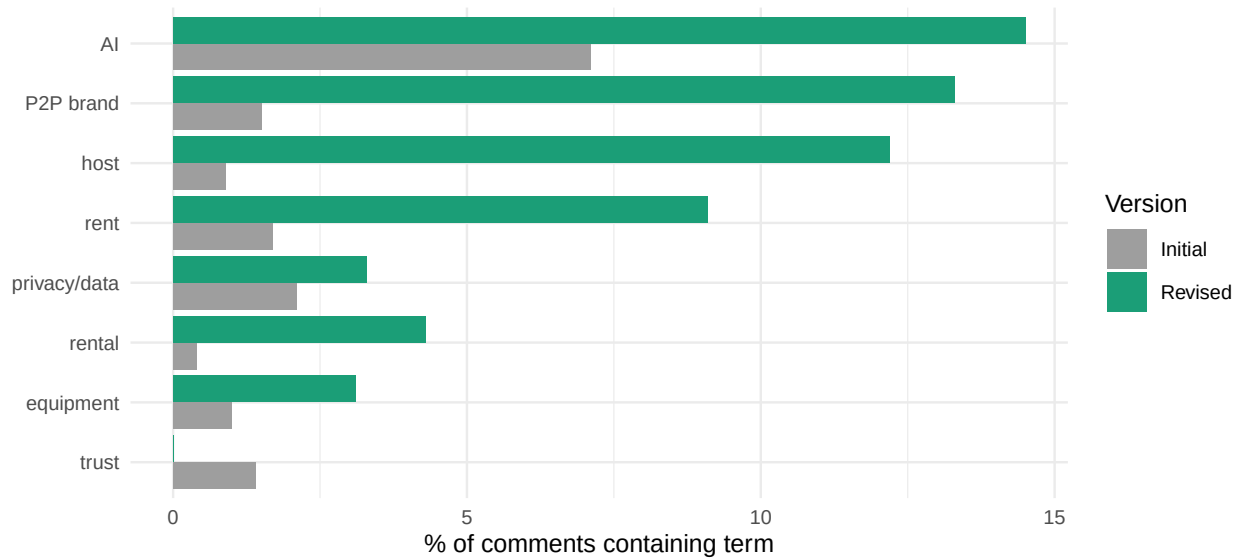


Figure 2: Share of comments containing each on-topic term. The revised scrape multiplies relevance on every dimension that matters for the brief (rental 11x, host 14x, peer-to-peer brands 9x).

Table 2: On-topic keyword coverage (% of comments).

Term	Initial	Revised
AI	7.1	14.5
rental	0.4	4.3

Term	Initial	Revised
rent	1.7	9.1
host	0.9	12.2
P2P brand	1.5	13.3
equipment	1.0	3.1
trust	1.4	0.0
privacy/data	2.1	3.3

5 Takeaways for the project

- **Relevance, not volume, was the problem.** The initial 14,090-comment corpus looked impressive but was mostly noise; the revised 483-comment corpus is ~6x denser in sharing-economy language (3.7% to 23.6% of comments mention sharing-economy terms).
- **The fix was methodological:** subreddit-scoped search + per-thread comment caps to stop viral threads dominating.
- **One honest caveat:** explicit use of the word “*trust*” actually *dropped* (1.4% to ~0%) in v2. Trust shows up *implicitly* through host/renter, payment and review language rather than the literal word — so we measure it through topics and sentiment, not keyword counts.
- **Decision:** we proceed with the **revised v2 corpus** for all downstream analysis (word frequencies, networks, LDA, sentiment), and keep the initial scrape only as a documented baseline of what *not* to do.